CORE COMPONENT

Grammar

Task Overview

In the **Grammar section**, you will answer **25 multiple-choice questions**. Each question consists of a short sentence with one missing word or phrase. You must choose the correct option from **three possible answers**.

Key points:

- Only one option is correct
- Each question focuses on one main grammar point
- Sentences test language at all levels: A1 — C1
- A good score can improve your results in **other components**!

General strategy

- Read the whole sentence before looking at the options, try to predict the type of grammar or words needed.
- Don't just choose the correct option, but try to reject the others: explain why they are wrong.
- Practise grammar questions to identify which areas you need to study more or review before the exam!

In this chapter, you will:

- Review some of the main grammar areas tested in the Core Component
- Learn how to recognise common Aptis grammar traps (**distractors**)
- Practise grammar questions in an exam-style format

Want more Aptis grammar practice?
Scan the QR code to access extra practice on the Seif Aptis Trainer. You can do general practice, or focus on specific grammar points or levels, with full explanations for every question

Grammar Prediction Task 1

In this section, we're going to see typical structures in grammar questions, and practise analysing the gaps before seeing the options.

For each sentence:

- Read each sentence, and think about the kind of grammar being tested
- Use the guiding questions to think about the gap and predict the missing words!
- Don't worry if you don't know the **grammatical concepts**! You will see the options on the next page.

A: The neighbour _____ fixed our Wi-Fi is an engineer.

Think about the gap:
Does it refer to a person or a thing? What is the subject of the verb "fixed"?

Possible answer(s): _____

B: We _____ the latest episode when the power went out.

Think about the gap:
Is the sentence about the past or the present? What verb could we use with "episode"?

Possible answer(s): _____

C: If we _____ to pack our camera, we would have taken photos.

Think about the gap:
Is the sentence about the past or the present? Is it a real or hypothetical situation? What verb form do we need after "if"?

Possible answer(s): _____

D: The contract _____ by the board of directors later this week.

Think about the gap:
We need a verb: past, present, or future? Who do you think does the action? The contract or the board of directors?

Possible answer(s): _____

E: They invited 100s of guests, but _____ people actually turned up.

Think about the gap:
Was there a large or small number of guests in the end? Is people singular or plural?

Possible answer(s): _____

Now look at the same sentences and **circle** the **correct option** for each sentence. Use the **clues** below for the sentence if you need them.

A: The neighbour _____ fixed our Wi-Fi is an engineer.

that | whom | which

Clue:
A "neighbour" is a person, so which option can we reject?
We need a **subject pronoun** for the verb "fixed". Which other pronoun can we reject?

B: We _____ the latest episode when the power went out.

watched | have watched | were watching

Clue:
The sentence is in the past (went out) so we need another past form.
Is the action "watch" before, after, or during the action "went out"?

C: If we _____ to pack our camera, we would have taken photos.

had remembered | would have remembered | would remember

Clue:
The sentence is talking about the past, and it is a hypothetical situation.
What kind of conditional is this? And what form of the verb do we use after "if"?

D: The contract _____ by the board of directors later this week.

is signed | will be signed | will sign

Clue:
"Later this week" means the sentence is talking about the future. The board of directors will do the action, so is the sentence active or passive voice?

E: They invited 100s of guests, but _____ people actually turned up.

little | few | many

Clue:
"but" suggests that there was a small number of guests in the end. "People" is countable — so which option can we reject?

Grammar Prediction Task 2

⚠️ This task is the same, but now we're going to focus on more advanced (C1) examples. Don't worry if you find them more difficult!

For each sentence:

- Read each sentence, and think about the kind of grammar being tested
- Use the guiding questions to think about the gap and predict the missing words!
- Don't worry if you don't know the **grammatical concepts**! You will see the options on the next page.

A: It's high time _____ studying harder. The exam is in two days!

Think about the gap:
What structures can we use after "it's time"? Is this a "real" or "unreal" structure?

Possible answer(s): _____

B: You _____ brought food — there was loads already!

Think about the gap:
Are we talking about the past, present or future? What might we use before "brought"?

Possible answer(s): _____

C: Seldom _____ so cold during the month of May.

Think about the gap:
What is a synonym of "seldom"? Normally, these adverbs go before a main verb. How does using it at the start of the sentence change the structure?

Possible answer(s): _____

D: She recommended _____ more alternative sources of protein.

Think about the gap:
What verb would fit this gap? What form of the verb do we use after "recommend"?

Possible answer(s): _____

E: In those days, they _____ in the mountains every summer.

Think about the gap:
Is this a past or a present situation? Is it a one-time action or a repeated one?

Possible answer(s): _____

Now look at the same sentences and **circle** the **correct option** for each sentence. Use the **clues** below for the sentence if you need them.

A: It's high time _____ studying harder. The exam is in two days!

you start | you started | to start

Clue:
"high time" is more emphatic than "it's time", and it requires a more specific structure. This is an "unreal" form — compare this with a hypothetical conditional!

B: You _____ brought food — there was loads already!

needn't have | didn't need to | needn't

Clue:
The key point here is that we use the participle "brought" and not the infinitive "bring". Which option can we reject? The sentence has a **past** meaning.

C: Seldom _____ so cold during the month of May.

has it been | has been it | it has been

Clue:
In sentences like this, where we put a negative adverb in the first position, we need **inversion**. What do you think that means in this case?

D: She recommended _____ more alternative sources of protein.

me to eat | eating | I eating

Clue:
Recommend is a tricky verb structure that only accepts certain verb patterns: Does it take a gerund (verb-ing) or an infinitive (to + verb)?

E: In those days, they _____ in their mountain house every summer.

were staying | use to stay | would stay

Clue:
This sentence refers to the past: "in those days", and it is a repeated, habitual action. Two options here refer to the past, but one is grammatically incorrect. Why?

Rejecting Incorrect Options

Sometimes options look correct at first, but can be eliminated because the grammar or meaning is wrong. It's important to learn how to **identify** and **reject** these options.

For each sentence:

- Read each sentence, and think about the kind of grammar being tested
- Decide why the option is incorrect: Wrong meaning / grammatical mistake? Can you think of an alternative option that would fit the gap correctly?

A: He **is having** dinner when I called.

When did the action happen?

Alternative answer? _____

B: The house **is built** right now. It should be finished in two weeks.

"Right now" is important — what form of the verb do we need?

Alternative answer? _____

C: Mary has decided that she needs **other** job as soon as possible

Is "job" singular or plural? Is it countable or uncountable?

Alternative answer? _____

D: **Despite** it was raining heavily, the match went on as planned.

What kind of structure can we use after "despite"?

Alternative answer? _____

E: If I had passed the speaking exam, I **would have worked** there today.

Is the result of the conditional in the past or the present?

Alternative answer? _____

F: Jane and Pete eat out a lot. **None of them** likes cooking very much.

How many people are we talking about?

Alternative answer? _____

G: The choice of dishes was poor. **However**, the service was awful.

What kind of link is there between the sentences? Is it a contrast?

Alternative answer? _____

Grammar Exam Practice

Now try some more grammar questions in exam conditions! 🚨 The following includes more examples of difficult questions than the real exam to help you prepare.

1: Dave _____ for twelve years now.

works | is working | has worked

2: He told me he _____ yesterday's meeting. I wonder what happened.

was going to attend | has attended | is going to attend

3: By the time I arrived, they _____ for nearly an hour.

have waited | had been waiting | were waiting

4: You _____ park here; it's for residents only.

don't have to | oughtn't | mustn't

5: I'm not very good _____ remembering names.

of | in | at

6: We studied this when we were at _____ university.

— | a | the

7: He denied _____ the classified documents from the office.

stealing | to steal | to have stolen

8: I'd rather _____ before it gets too late.

to leave | we leave | we left

9: If you _____ to the instructions, you won't have any problems.

listened | listen | will listen

10: The colleague to _____ I spoke was very helpful.

which | whom | who

11: You have your own car, _____?

don't you | haven't you | have you

12: Rarely _____ such a convincing argument.

I have heard | heard I | have I heard

13: A: I usually do my homework just before class. B: So _____ I!

am | do | have

14: I wish I _____ enough to buy my own house.

was pay | were paid | am paid

15: Petra _____ in New Mexico

lives | living | live

16: You really _____ to study harder if you hope to pass the exam!

should | must | ought

17: Apparently, she's _____ start university in September.

going | go to | going to

18: I _____ it doesn't rain on your trip next weekend.

wish | hope | want

19: _____ Mont Blanc is the highest mountain in the Alps.

The | — | A

20: If you did more exercise, you _____ a lot more energy.

had have | will have | would have

21: Each candidate _____ to provide full references in their application

is required | are required | requires

22: David invited all his friends, but _____ came.

nobody | anyone | somebody

23: Nowadays, our children show _____ interest in reading.

few | little | fewer

24: By the time you get here, the film _____.

will finish | will have finished | is finishing

25: After many hours, they finally succeeded _____ fixing the gate.

in | at | on

Want more Grammar practice?

Scan the QR code to access the grammar section of the Seif Aptis Trainer. Practise random questions or train specific grammar points or levels (A2-C1)